

Prêt-à-Portable

Rossi Fernandes &
Kumar Jhuremalani

Many would agree that notebooks or laptops were considered tools for the elite businessmen under a decade ago. That is no longer the case. Today, students carry them to school and colleges. Some even use it as their only computer because they make for a simpler purchase than a desktop PC, and a convenient one.

Price played a part in this shift of perception. Notebooks were expensive once, well beyond the reach of all but the elite businessmen that carried them; they have dropped in prices over the years. Today, you can easily purchase an entry-level laptop for less than Rs. 25,000. Still, there are a few problems with notebooks even though they are this cheap. Although they have become smaller and more powerful, power consumption also has gone up and down went their battery life. Thus most laptops that you can buy for around

Rs. 25,000 will have a battery life of about two hours. The other problem with laptops this cheap is they are heavy and painful to lug around; not exactly portable at that. While there is a solution — to opt for ultra-portable notebooks, these typically start at around Rs. 75,000 and they are often out of the reach of most of us looking for portability.

The year 2008 changed the status quo though. It saw a wave of notebooks hit our shores with the launch of the highly anticipated, low-power processors from Intel called the Atom. The Atom processor was (relatively) cheap, small and power efficient. With the first Atom processors sprouted brands that used these in their low-power notebooks. These were quickly called netbooks and they were targeted at users who wanted affordable laptops. Netbooks are so-called as they happen to be best suited for tasks of surfing the internet, along with mild office usage.

Looking for a light notebook that won't break the bank? Then a netbook is what you need

The first question to ask here is why anyone would want to buy a netbook. To start with, it's probably not the best thing to own as your primary computer: if you have no other PC or laptop, a netbook won't serve you best. At least not today, who knows what future processors bring to this segment... With that caveat, there are many scenarios that fit netbooks perfectly. They have long battery lives so you can get the same battery performance you would get on an expensive, power-efficient laptop. Netbooks make great second computers to own. You can carry them wherever you want. You can use them to browse the internet while sitting in the living room on the couch, watching a game of cricket on TV. Unlike most "laptops" these will actually fit in your laps and not run as hot as to burn you. For those who would like to buy a cheap PC, a netbook could be an option to consider — just remember that you will have to do without an optical drive, as well as with a very cramped keyboard.

Photo: Jiten Gandhi
Imaging: Shrikrishna Patkar



Today, almost every brand has a netbook to offer. This is then the right time for us to do a small comparison of the netbooks available in the market. We received seven netbooks from six brands. One of the newest netbooks to come to India was the BenQ Joybook Lite U101. We weren't given a price for this yet.

Acer Aspire One

The Acer Aspire One was one of the first netbooks to arrive in India, along with the ASUS Eee PC and the MSI Wind. This is a smaller laptop in comparison to the others. The Aspire One comes with a 9-inch screen much like the ASUS 904HA. The big difference is that the size of the Aspire is a lot smaller than the ASUS Eee PC 904HA.

When it was released, many considered the Aspire One to be the best looking netbooks and its blue-coloured avatar was proudly

Acer Aspire One



How We Tested

Netbooks aren't meant for high-end gaming or even for power-users. Having read up and followed developments on netbooks for a while, it was expected that almost all the brands would be very close in performance, ruling out performance as the deciding factor while purchasing one. We modified our laptop comparison test sheets to better suit the netbooks. PCMark 2005 was used as the primary test for desktop application performance. We even ran an older 3DMark - 2005 on the netbooks to measure graphic subsystem performance. We also used SiSoft Sandra as a synthetic benchmark to gauge other subsystems including the memory subsystem and the hard drive.

One of the most important points we focused on was the battery life test. A video was run with the brightness of the screen and volume turned up. Some of the netbooks had built-in overclocking and battery saving features, which were all turned off for the test.

We decided to run Far Cry just to see what kind of gaming performance we could get from the netbooks. We also did a DivX video compression test and a WinRAR benchmark to measure processing power.

Scores and ratings were also given to the other features of the netbooks. We looked at screen quality, audio quality, build quality, touchpad and many other aspects of the netbooks.

exhibited in almost every mall across the country. It was this netbook that we received. This One has a glossy finish on the top and on the insides surrounding the screen. The hinge of the Aspire One houses its status LEDs and the ends of the hinge have an orange tip compliments the look and finish of the netbook.

Build quality of the Acer One is average; the outer shell feels right but the keyboards have a light feel. Pressing them doesn't require a lot of effort and the keys feel slightly wobbly.

Speaking of the keyboard, we come to perhaps the biggest negative of netbooks — being such small laptops, they keyboards accordingly shrink in size. For the Aspire One, the keys are smaller all

throughout the keyboard. The touchpad too is small with the mouse buttons positioned vertically instead of horizontally. Although getting used to the limited surface area of the touchpad is a problem for everyone, the buttons were easier to get used to over time. The touchpad is so small that you have to swipe your finger many times vertically to move the pointer from the top to the bottom of the screen. Even changing the mouse sensitivity didn't help a lot.

The audio quality is fine and fairly detailed; just not loud enough. If you think you might watch movies or TV shows on this netbook, you might need either laptop speakers or a good set of headphones. The screen isn't so great for movie watching either: viewing angles aren't forgiving and the backlight bleeding is clearly visible.

If anyone gets the impression that this isn't a good netbook, then they are mistaken. Netbooks were expected to be under Rs 20,000 before they were to be released. Manufacturing costs drove the prices over that mark

but today. Acer has informed us that the price for the Aspire One is Rs 20,000 and it differs from model to model. The pricing for it on online shopping sites when we last checked for the Aspire One with Linux was around some Rs. 14,500 and the one with Windows XP is Rs. 17,500. The Acer Aspire One in that case is good value for money.

ASUS Eee PC 904HA and 1000H

The ASUS EeePC 1000H and the 904HA are almost identical to each other in shape and design. With their lids shut, the only real way to tell them apart is to look for the 1000H's protruding battery. The 904HA we received came with a 6600mAh battery.

The 904HA, as its name suggests, has a 9-inch screen and the 1000H, a 10-inch one. The 904HA has two thick panels on the either side of its screen which look like speakers at first but the speakers are in fact at the bottom, for both these netbooks.

ASUS Eee PC 904HA



One of the complaints laid out at the Eee PC's feet has to be about its small and narrow vents that run down the side of the netbook. This makes the Eee PC heat up a little more than the others as there isn't a lot of air ventilation within the chassis. The Eee PC netbooks also look plain and don't stand out much. The keys feel a little flimsy and the mouse buttons for the touchpad are a bit tacky as well. One of the unique features of the Eee